

Fate's Edge: Game Master's Guide

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Chapter 1

Introduction: The Weight of Choice

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a unique role in **Fate's Edge**. You are not a solitary storyteller, nor a neutral referee. You are the **weaver of consequences**, the architect of a living world, and the guide on a path where every choice echoes. Your task is to breathe life into a realm of ancient magic, fallen empires, and vibrant cultures—and then let that world respond to the players' ambitions.

Power demands a price. The past never truly sleeps. One decision can reshape a nation or end an age. From the marble forums of Ecktoria to the mist-drenched fens of the Mistlands, the world is alive with stories. Your job is to provide the stage, set the stakes, and embrace the ripple effects of player agency.

1.1 A World Alive with Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, the fiction is the final authority. The rules are not chains on your imagination, but tools to give weight to your stories. They help you adjudicate risk, track progress, and ensure that both success and failure drive the narrative forward.

Think of yourself as a conductor. The players provide the melody with their characters' actions. You provide the harmony and rhythm with the world's response. The rules are your sheet music—a guide to create a cohesive, dramatic piece, but one that allows improvisation.

Your judgment is the cornerstone of the game. If a rule doesn't serve the moment, change it. If a player's creative idea deserves to succeed, make it work. Your goal is a collaborative story that everyone helps create.

1.2 Core Philosophy: Narrative First

At the heart of **Fate's Edge** is a simple idea: **mechanics serve the story**. A dice roll is never just pass/fail. It changes the fictional landscape.

- **Clean Success** – The plan works as intended.
- **Success with Cost** – You get what you want, but the world pushes back.
- **Partial** – You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved.
- **Miss** – You fail, and the situation escalates.

This ensures every roll matters. The story never stalls; it evolves.

1.3 Risk as the Engine of Drama

Fate's Edge is built on **meaningful risk**. Safety is boring. When characters have something to lose—reputation, allies, ideals, life—their actions become heroic or tragically memorable.

Your primary tool for managing risk is the **Story Beat (SB)** economy. When the dice show a **1**, the world reacts. The GM gains SB to introduce complications, escalate threats, or reveal hidden dangers. **Important:** SB are generated on *any* roll that produces a 1, whether the overall roll succeeds or fails. They are not punishment; they are fuel for an unpredictable, responsive narrative.

Example: A successful sword swing defeats an opponent. A Story Beat spent could mean the blade is notched, or that the defeat draws a more powerful foe. The drama continues.

1.4 Characters Who Change the World

Character growth in **Fate's Edge** is not about accumulating abstract power. It is **meaningful growth** rooted in the story. Players earn **Experience Points (XP)** by engaging with challenges and complexities. They spend XP to improve capabilities, acquire assets (a ship, a spy network), or unlock cultural talents.

Thus, advancement ties directly to narrative. A character becomes a legendary commander by leading armies, not by grinding monsters. A wizard masters forbidden lore by surviving backlash. As GM, you curate this growth, presenting challenges that make evolution feel earned and impactful.

1.5 Your Toolkit

To help guide the story, **Fate's Edge** provides interconnected tools:

- **Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s. 6+ = Success. 1 = Story Beat (SB) for you. Compare successes to Difficulty Value (DV) set by stakes.
- **Position & Effect:** Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) defines stakes of failure. Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) describes what a clean success achieves.
- **Clocks:** Visual trackers for ongoing challenges (e.g., 4-segment lock, 8-segment faction rise).
- **Deck of Consequences (optional):** A standard deck to generate thematic complications when SB are spent. Suits suggest nature of trouble.

These tools are designed to be learned quickly and used intuitively, getting out of the way so you and your players focus on the story.

1.6 How to Use This Book

This guide is for running the game.

- Early chapters cover core principles and basic procedures.
- Later chapters dive into advanced systems (conflict, travel, long-term play).
- Final sections provide guidance for high-tier campaigns, world-building, and the Amaranthine Sea setting.
- Appendices offer practical advice and a collection of tools and tables.

You don't need to memorize everything. Use this book as a reference. The most important chapters to internalize are those on core philosophy (this chapter) and basic action resolution (see SRD ??).

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes – conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table must always feel safe. Use these three simple tools.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” or say “X” when uncomfortable. The described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations. The scene is retconned or redirected.

Lines. A hard boundary: content that will not appear at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Players name their Lines before the campaign; the group honors them.

Veils. A soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils let you acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use.

- Establish Lines and Veils in Session Zero. Write them down where everyone can see.
- Keep an X-Card visible (printed card, drawn X, or digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate.
- The GM is also a player; they may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust they had a good reason.

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the table to tell darker, more intense stories because everyone knows they can tap out. A safe game is a game that can go to the edge.

Flavor is Free

Players and GMs: In Fate's Edge, flavor is free!

Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or rolls. Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect.

Flavor enriches narrative and makes the world feel real. It doesn't change mechanical outcomes, but it defines the *how* and the *why*. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure; flavor determines the story we tell about it.

A Guide for Veterans: Fate's Edge in a Nutshell

If you're experienced with other RPGs, here's a quick translation of how **Fate's Edge** handles common concepts:

Traditional RPG Concept	Fate's Edge Approach
Ability Scores & Skills	Attributes (Body, Wits, etc.) + Skills (Melee, Lore, etc.) form a dice pool.
Skill Checks	Roll Attribute+Skill pool. Count successes (6+). Compare to DV. Any 1s give GM SB.
Hit Points / Health	Harm Track for injuries. Fatigue for exhaustion. Consequences are narrative and mechanical.
Combat Rounds	Fiction-first. Actions resolved by narrative timing, not rigid initiative.
Spell Slots / Mana	Magic uses the same core system. 1s generate SB. Powerful spells may require extra time or risk.
Saving Throws	Roll Attribute+Skill to resist (e.g., Body+Resolve vs. poison).
Experience & Leveling Up	Gain XP through play. Spend to increase Attributes/Skills, buy Talents, or acquire Assets. Growth is player-directed.

The key difference is a consistent, unified mechanic applied across all challenges, focused on narrative outcomes.

1.7 Begin the Journey

Your role is a privilege and a creative challenge. You are a facilitator, a fan of the players, and the keeper of a world that will challenge and surprise them. Trust the rules to handle tension, trust your players to drive the story, and trust yourself to weave it all together.

Now, take a breath. Shuffle the deck. Let the dice fall.

It's time to guide the edge of fate.

Chapter 2

Running the Game: Core Procedures

2.1 How to Think in Fate’s Edge

Running **Fate’s Edge** is less about adjudicating difficulty and more about managing momentum. Your primary job is not to block success, protect outcomes, or simulate realism—it is to **frame pressure, track consequences, and let the fiction move forward**.

If you catch yourself asking “How hard should this be?” you are already one step behind. Instead ask:

- What is at stake right now?
- What happens if this goes wrong?
- What pressure is already in play?

The rules exist to answer those questions—not to replace them.

2.1.1 The Core Loop (In Practice)

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop:

1. **Player declares intent and approach.**
2. **You state Position and set any relevant Clocks.**
3. **The roll resolves the moment.**
4. **You apply consequences and update the fiction.**

Do not search for the “right roll.” If the action matters, the procedure applies.

2.1.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt, trust the fiction. The system will follow. Fall back on these defaults:

- **DV:** 3
- **Position:** Controlled
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

Escalate only when the fiction demands it.

2.1.3 What You Are Not Doing

You are *not*:

- calling for rolls to gate progress
- inflating difficulty to “challenge” the players
- protecting NPC plans from disruption
- hiding information behind unnecessary checks

If the players act decisively, the world must respond decisively.

2.1.4 What You Are Doing

You *are*:

- stating Position clearly and confidently
- letting partials move the story forward
- spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- allowing success to create new problems

The game works best when nothing stalls.

2.1.5 A Useful Reframe

Think of each scene as a **pressure engine**:

- Dice create outcomes
- Clocks track fallout
- Story Beats fuel escalation
- Boons reward risk

Your job is to keep that engine turning—not to decide where it ends.

Let the procedures do the work. Your attention belongs on the fiction.

2.2 Optional Initiative Procedures

Fate's Edge uses **narrative initiative** by default: the GM frames spotlight based on the fiction. However, some tables prefer more structure, especially during complex combat. The following optional procedures are compatible with the core rules.

2.2.1 When to Use Structured Initiative

Consider structured initiative when:

- Combat involves six or more participants.
- Players want a clear, rotating turn order.
- The table enjoys tactical positioning and resource management.
- You mix groups with different speeds or reaction times.

Even with structured systems, prioritize the fiction: an ambusher still acts first.

2.2.2 Option A: Popcorn Initiative

Each round, the player who just acted chooses who goes next (friend or foe). The GM may veto unrealistic skips (e.g., an archer at Far acting before the enemy in Close).

IX Step Procedure	
1	Determine first actor by fiction (ambush, fastest PC, etc.).
2	That character takes their full turn.
3	After their turn, they choose any other character who has not acted this round to go next.
4	Repeat until all have acted.
5	End of round: last actor chooses first actor of the next round.

2.2.2.0.1 GM Guidance Use popcorn initiative to reward clever positioning. Enemies will naturally gang up on vulnerable PCs if players always choose foes – that's fine. If the table feels unfair, limit choice to “adjacent in fiction” (e.g., only those within Near range).

2.2.3 Option B: Side-Based Initiative

All player characters act together, then all enemies act together (or vice versa). Order within the side is negotiated by players.

IX Step Procedure	
1	Determine which side has surprise or narrative advantage. That side acts first.
2	All members of that side take their turns in any order (players decide).
3	All members of the other side take their turns.
4	Repeat.

2.2.3.0.1 GM Guidance Best for large combats (10+ combatants). To avoid “alpha strikes,” separate enemy groups into two initiatives (e.g., “archers” and “berserkers”) that act on different counts.

2.2.4 Option C: Speed-Based Slots

Each character rolls a die (e.g., 1d10 + Wits) for initiative. Higher scores act first. Ties go to the PC, or roll off.

IX

Step Procedure

-
- 1 At combat start, each player rolls 1d10 + Wits (or other attribute).
 - 2 The GM rolls once for each distinct enemy group (or individually for bosses).
 - 3 Order all participants by score highest to lowest.
 - 4 Act in that order.
 - 5 After each full round, optionally re-roll to reflect changing conditions.
-

2.2.4.0.1 GM Guidance Familiar to traditional players. Use a visible tracker (whiteboard, index cards). Re-rolling each round adds chaos but slows play slightly.

2.2.5 Mixing Narrative and Structured Initiative

Even with a structured system, override it when fiction demands. Examples:

- A PC triggers a trap mid-round → they act immediately, then initiative resumes.
- An enemy surrenders → remove them from the order; do not skip a player's turn.
- A character is delayed (e.g., climbing a wall) → they act at end of round regardless of score.

Always state your override clearly: “The bridge collapses—Kaelen, you react first. Everyone else, hold your action.”

2.2.6 Recommendation for New GMs

Start with **narrative initiative** for the first 2–3 sessions. Once players are comfortable with Position and DV, introduce **popcorn initiative** for combat. Reserve side-based or speed-based for large, tactical fights. The best system keeps the fiction moving.

2.3 Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules

This rule makes each player the primary steward of their character-facing trackers (*modules*). It keeps table pace high, reduces hidden bookkeeping, and clarifies when mechanical thresholds trigger. The GM retains authority over world-facing clocks, faction fronts, and major narrative consequences.

2.3.1 Scope (What Counts as a Module)

Player-managed modules are any **character-facing** clocks, counters, or discrete states on a single character sheet:

- **Obligation** (per Patron or Symbol)
- **Corruption Clock** (Cantor)
- **Leash** (Summoned spirit strain) and **Spirit Bond Clock**
- **Repertoire Clock** (Cantor) or similar progression clocks
- **Asset States** (Maintained / Neglected / Compromised / Shattered)
- **Scene Counters** explicitly tied to a PC (Exposure, personal Buff/Debuff durations)

Not included: GM story resources (global **Story Beats**), location/faction clocks, and mystery/doom fronts.

What Players Track (at a Glance)

11X

Module Owner Tick / Change Triggers (examples)

Obligation (by Patron) Player Invoke/Push/ritual text; Invoker *Borrowed Grace*; cracking a Symbol; bargain costs.

Corruption Clock Player Cantor Push; Resonant Rite; GM spends a Beat tied to the PC's occult actions.

Leash (Summoning) Player Harm to spirit; commands against nature; split focus; crossing [WARD] (DV = Cap).

Spirit Bond [4] Player Shared victories, mutual aid, meaningful attempts (once/session/type).

Repertoire [6] Player Learn a new unique Song/rite-as-song; practice milestones.

Asset State (Symbol) Player Maintenance/downtime checks; *Crack the Seal* → Compromised; breakage → Shattered.

2.3.2 Core Principle

Players **immediately** mark their own modules when a rule says “mark +X” or a trigger fires. Threshold effects resolve as soon as reached.

2.3.3 Player Duties

1. **Mark on Cue.** When you Invoke a Rite, Push, spend/clear per rules, or a trigger fires, update your module *now*, not later.
2. **Declare Thresholds.** If marking fills a clock or crosses capacity, say so aloud; thresholds resolve before the scene proceeds.
3. **State Ownership.** Keep per-Patron Obligation tallies distinct; track each Symbol's state.
4. **Keep It Visible.** Use a tracker the GM and table can see (sheet boxes, index cards, or shared digital).

2.3.4 GM Duties

1. **Spot-Check.** At need, ask any player: current Obligation by Patron, Corruption segments, Leash state, Asset states.
2. **Enforce Thresholds.** When a player reports a threshold, apply standard effects *immediately*.
3. **Own the Fallout.** Patron intrusions, faction reactions, front clocks, and major narrative consequences remain GM authority.

2.3.5 Standard Thresholds & Effects

2.3.5.0.1 Obligation Capacity

$$\text{ObligationCapacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

- **Over Capacity:** Mark **+1 Fatigue** per segment over capacity.
- **Over 2× Capacity:** Clear all Fatigue, mark **+1 Harm (Stress)**, and a **Patron Intrusion** occurs (GM frames on-theme demand/complication).

2.3.5.0.2 Corruption Full When a **Corruption Clock** fills:

- Apply the last-Patron **benefit & burden** to the PC (and any listed followers/retainers).
- **Reset** the Corruption Clock to empty.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, convert the current Patron theme into a permanent boon/curse (see full rules).

2.3.5.0.3 Leash Full (Summoning) When the **Leash** fills:

- The spirit acts once to its nature, then **departs** (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Leash Capacity: $Cap + Spirit$ segments. (Cap is the outsider's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater.)

2.3.5.0.4 Symbol State (Invoker)

- **Maintained** → normal function.
- **Neglected** → GM may impose +1 DV to related rites.
- **Compromised** (e.g., *Crack the Seal*) → instant resolution per rules; mark extra Obligation; repair in Downtime or pay 1 XP.
- **Shattered** → unusable until replaced or ritually restored.

2.3.6 Table Procedure (90-Second Loop)

2.3.6.0.1 Start of Session Players read out: per-Patron Obligation totals, Corruption segments, standing Asset States, and any personal clocks at 3+.

2.3.6.0.2 End of Scene Quick pass: “Any marks?” Players tick modules from scene events. If a threshold triggers, resolve now.

2.3.6.0.3 Downtime Players apply clears (service, contrition, purification, study) to their own modules. GM verifies any costs or fiction.

2.3.7 Disputes & Order of Operations

If two marks land simultaneously, apply them in the **least advantageous order for the acting character**, unless a rule specifies otherwise. The GM is final arbiter.

2.3.8 Accessibility & Tools

Use highly visible trackers: bold boxes on sheets, poker chips for segments, or a shared per-Patron Obligation table. Keep modules at-a-glance to minimize interruption.

2.3.9 Worked Micro-Examples

- **Invoker Rites Twice:** Vessa Invokes two different Patrons. She marks each Patron's Obligation separately. Hitting capacity with Patron A causes Fatigue; Patron B stays below.
- **Cantor Pushes:** Jorel Pushes a Song (mark +1 Corruption). That fills his clock; he gains last-Patron boon/burden immediately, then resets to 0.
- **Summoner Clash:** Kestra's Cap 3 elemental takes Harm and crosses a [WARD]; she ticks her Leash twice. On fill, the elemental flares once and departs.

The Core Loop: Your First 10 Games

Start here for your first session! Ignore advanced systems until comfortable.

1. Player states Goal & Action (Attribute + Skill)
2. GM sets simple DV (2–5)
3. Player rolls. Count Successes (6+)
4. GM consults Outcome Matrix. **Ignore Boons for now. Use simple complications on Partial/Miss.**

Once comfortable, add: Boons | Story Beats | Clocks

First Game Scenario: The Sunstone Tower

Premise: The party is hired to infiltrate the ruined Sunstone Tower and retrieve a magical sunstone before rival treasure hunters do. This scenario uses a limited rules subset perfect for beginners.

- **Ignore for this scenario:** Boons, Corruption, intricate magic subsystems, detailed Follower/Asset upkeep.
- **Focus on:** Core dice pool, Success/Partial/Miss outcomes, Position, Clocks.
- **Character Setup:** Use pregenerated characters or create simple ones with 20 XP and 2–3 clear hooks.

GM Prep in 10 Minutes

[Sunstone Tower Prep Checklist]

- Name 3 NPCs: hirer, rival delver, tower spirit (or echo).
- Write 1 sentence for each scene: Approach, Interior, Sunstone Chamber.
- Create 2 clocks: **Guardian Alert** [4] and **Tower Collapse** [6].
- Decide 1 twist: rival arrives early, tower shifts, or sunstone is not what it seems.

Scene 1: The Approach

Lane Marker: Skill Challenge with a Clock

GM Focus: Practice calls for DV and Partial outcomes. For this intro, tick the **Guardian Alert** [4] clock on a Partial or Miss.

The tower stands on a cliffside. Players must navigate three challenges:

- Cross the crumbling bridge (Athletics) – DV 3
- Scale the cliff face (Athletics/Strength) – DV 4
- Sneak past the stone guardians (Stealth) – DV 3

Guardian Alert Clock [4]: Each Partial or Miss advances the clock by 1. If filled, guardians activate and pursue; treat them as a single *Tower Guardian* threat with a simple [4] Harm track.

Scene 2: The Tower Interior

This scene teaches **Position** and **environmental stakes**.

- **Dominant:** “You have the high ground on the crumbling staircase, looking down on the patrol.”
- **Controlled:** “The hallway is dark but quiet. You can take your time, but there might be traps.”
- **Desperate:** “The floor gives way beneath you as you lunge for the door!”

[How to Set Position in Play]

- **Listen First:** Hear the player’s intent and approach. What are they actually doing in the fiction?
- **Assess the Situation:** Consider leverage, opposition, time pressure, exposure, and consequences. Ask: *How forgiving is the world right now?*
- **Assign the Position:**
 - **Dominant:** Clear leverage, surprise, or overwhelming advantage.
 - **Controlled:** Stable; mistakes are recoverable.
 - **Desperate:** Exposed, rushed, cornered, or facing serious danger.
- **State It Clearly:** Say it out loud before the roll. “*This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, the consequences will be serious.*”

Reminder: Position is a statement of risk and consequence, not a reward or penalty. It frames what failure *means*.

Scene 3: The Sunstone Chamber

The chamber is collapsing as rival delvers close in. Use a simple [6] clock for the collapse. Each round, the clock ticks up by 1. On each Miss, advance it by an extra 1 segment.

- **Goal:** Retrieve the sunstone and escape before the clock fills.
- **On Fill:** The chamber seals. Escape requires a final, Desperate group action.

Lane Marker: One New Idea at a Time

Scene 1: Clocks *only*.

Scene 2: Add *Position*.

Scene 3: Combine *Clocks + Position*. Reserve Boons, Corruption, and advanced magic for later sessions.

2.4 Learning Through Examples

This section walks the same situation through multiple passes, adding one rule at a time. Use it as a mental template when you improvise.

Example 1: Core Loop Only**Example 1 – No SB, No Boons**

Lyra tries to sneak past a guardian in a narrow hallway. (Agility + Stealth = 5d10).
 GM: normal risk, DV 3, Controlled Position.
 Roll: 3, 5, 6, 7, 9 → 3 successes (6,7,9).
 DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success**.
 GM: “You slip past the guardian quietly. You’re in position behind it if you want to act.”

Example 2: Add Story Beats Only**Example 2 – Adding Story Beats**

Same situation. Lyra rolls 5d10: 1, 4, 6, 6, 8.
 Successes: 3 (6,6,8). One 1 → 1 SB for GM.
 DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success** with 1 SB.
 GM spend (1 SB = Minor): “You get past the guardian, but your cloak snags and tears. The sound echoes – the next room has a –1 Position penalty for stealth checks.”

Example 3: Add Boons Only**Example 3 – Adding Boons**

Later, Lyra scales a loose stone wall (Athletics + Agility = 4d10). DV 3.
 Roll: 2,3,4,5 → 0 successes = **Miss**.
 GM awards **2 Boons**. “You slip and land hard, taking 1 Harm. Mark 2 Boons – you can use them later to turn the tide.”
 Next attempt, Lyra spends 1 Boon to re-roll a die, turning failure into success.

Example 4: Putting It Together**Example 4 – SB + Boons + Position**

The party flees as the tower collapses. A crumbling staircase blocks the exit.
 GM: “Desperate. DV 4 to get everyone across safely.”
 Lyra leads, rolling 6d10 (Agility + Athletics + help): 1,2,6,7,7,9.
 4 successes vs DV 4 = **Success**. 1 rolled 1 = 1 SB to GM. Desperate Position.
 GM: “You all make it across, but the last step collapses behind you. I spend 1 SB: your exit path is gone. You’ll need a new way out.”
Lesson: Even on a success, SB let you bend the fiction toward drama without erasing the player’s win.

2.5 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes.

3. **Establish Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate.
4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check Against DV** using Outcome Matrix.
7. **Apply Outcome:** Success, Partial, or Miss.
8. **Spend SB** for complications and twists.

2.5.0.0.1 Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats generated unless specified. Fiction advances cleanly.

2.5.0.0.2 Success with Cost. Action succeeds but generates **Story Beats**. Success stands; cost is GM spending those SB, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

2.5.0.0.3 Miss. Action fails and generates **Story Beats**. GM uses those SB to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

2.5.0.0.4 Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates progress but not full resolution. How that manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

2.5.0.0.5 Example: Lockpicking. A character picks a DV 3 lock.

- **1 success (Partial):** Lock loosens but not opened; character gains *Controlled Position* on next attempt.
- **2 successes (Strong Partial):** Lock opens – GM spends the generated **Story Beat** to upgrade to *Success with Cost* (lock jams behind them, or someone hears the click).

2.5.0.0.6 Guiding Principle. Partials represent *meaningful progress*. Convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

[Position Effects] IX

Position Mechanical Effect

Dominant May re-roll one failure (die < 6).

Controlled Default state; no re-rolls.

Desperate Must re-roll one success (die 6+), keeping second result.

[Difficulty Ladder – Beginner Focus] IX

DV When to Use

-
- 2 Routine: clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
 - 3 Default: mild challenge, some risk – use most often.
 - 4 Hard: serious opposition, bad angle, or strong resistance.
 - 5+ Extreme: major boss encounters or dramatic gambles.
-

2.6 Story Beats: The Engine of Drama

Every time a player rolls a 1, you gain Story Beats (SB). These are narrative tools, not punishments.

[SB Spend Menu] IX

SB Cost Simple Complications

-
- 1 SB Minor: noise, distraction, small setback, lost gear.
 - 2 SB Moderate: alarm raised, new threat enters, lose advantage.
 - 3+ SB Major: reinforcements, scene shifts, stakes escalate.
-

2.6.1 Failing Forward with SB

- **On Success:** Use SB to add texture. The hero wins, but something changes.
- **On Partial:** The hero gets what they wanted *and* you spend SB to add cost or threat.
- **On Miss:** Spend SB to make the setback sharper, broader, or longer-lasting.

Lane Marker: One Complication per Roll

When in doubt, spend SB on *one* clear complication instead of many small ones. Name it plainly – “Guard Alerted”, “Floor Cracked”, “Oath Owed” – and move on.

Be **aggressive** with Story Beats, but never arbitrary:

- Do not hoard SB – unused pressure is wasted momentum.
- Do not invent contrived consequences that ignore the fiction.
- Spend SB to *sharpen what already matters*, not to add noise.

A single, well-chosen complication should change the situation, not just decorate it.

2.7 Combat Made Simple

Combat uses the same core loop. The stakes are higher and more immediate.

[Combat Quick Reference]

- **Initiative:** No fixed order. Ask: “Who acts next?” Follow the fiction.
- **Actions:** Each turn, a character can move and take one meaningful action.
- **Position Matters:** Flanking or ambush → Dominant; surrounded or exposed → Desperate.
- **Use Clocks:** Track enemy morale [6], environmental dangers [4], and boss thresholds.

2.7.1 Three-Beat Combat Structure

When lost in a fight, fall back on three beats:

1. **Opening Exchange:** Establish where everyone is and what they want.
2. **Turning Point:** Spend SB or tick clocks to change the situation (reinforcements, terrain shifts).
3. **Final Gamble:** Make the last few rolls matter – higher DV, Desperate Position, or big rewards.

Example: SB in Combat

The party fights bandits on a collapsing bridge.

On a Partial, GM spends 2 SB: “You push them back, but the bridge loses another support. The *Bridge Collapse* [4] clock advances.”

Now every action is also about whether they escape in time.

2.8 Clocks & Fronts

Clocks are visual trackers for threats, progress, and looming changes. They keep pressure visible and shared.

2.8.1 Basic Clock Usage

- **Size:** [4] for small scenes, [6] for bigger problems, [8] for arcs.
- **Advance On:** Misses, certain Partials, or SB spends.
- **Name It:** “Alarm Raised [4]” or “Floodwaters Rise [6]” is better than a blank circle.

[Beginner Clock Limits]

- No more than 3 active clocks per scene.
- Only 1–2 clocks should matter to the current roll.
- Say out loud when you tick a clock and why.

2.8.2 Mini-Fronts for Short Arcs

A *Front* is a cluster of related clocks and threats.

- **Example Front:** “Rival Delvers of the Sunstone Tower”
- **Clocks:** “Rivals Close In [6]”, “Tower Integrity [6]”, “Rival Reputation [4]”.
- Each time you spend SB, consider ticking one of these clocks.

2.9 Ready for More? Add These Systems

Once comfortable with the core loop, introduce these modules one at a time. Treat each as a new lane marker.

2.9.1 Boons

Boons reward players for pushing their luck.

- On **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons.
- On **Partial:** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Spend:** Re-roll a die, add +1 Effect, or seize a small advantage (GM-approved).

Start with *re-roll only*. Once players are comfortable, add the other options.

2.9.2 Advanced Magic

- **Basic:** Use simple Tag-based magic (single roll, single tag).
- **Intermediate:** Add Runekeepers after 2–3 sessions, when everyone understands SB and Clocks.
- **Advanced:** Introduce Invokers and ritual magic for groups that enjoy planning and complex payoffs.

2.9.3 Followers, Assets, and Domains

Add persistent resources when the group cares about territory, organizations, or long-term projects.

- Start with 1 simple Follower or Asset each.
- Tie them to clocks: “Caravan Reputation [6]”, “Temple Influence [4]”.
- Spend SB to threaten or complicate these resources.

2.10 Session Flow: A GM Cognitive Checklist

Use this as a quiet mental script. You do not need to say any of it out loud.

2.10.1 Opening 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What does everyone want out of tonight?” (goal, vibe, focus).
- Recap 2–3 key facts and 1 unresolved clock.
- Ask each player: “What is your character worried about right now?”

2.10.2 During Play

- Before a roll: Name DV, Position, and stakes.
- After a roll: Say the outcome type (Success/Partial/Miss) first, then the fiction.
- Between scenes: Look at clocks. Ask, “Which one should move? What changes in the world?”

2.10.3 Closing 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What was your favorite moment?” (signals what to do more of).
- Note any clocks that reached halfway or full.
- Jot 2 bullet points: “Next time on Fate’s Edge...” as hooks.

Quick GM Cheat Sheet

- **DV Default:** 3 (adjust ± 1 for ease/difficulty).
- **Position:** Controlled (normal), Dominant (advantage), Desperate (risk).
- **SB Spend:** 1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication.
- **Max Clocks:** 3 per scene to avoid overwhelm.
- **Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Remember: The goal is to tell an exciting story together. These rules are tools, not tests. Start simple, add complexity when ready, and keep lane markers clear: one new idea at a time, one clear consequence per roll, and one or two clocks that really matter.

Figure 2.1: Fate's Edge systems: the Core Loop drives SB/Clocks/Modules/Boons; pressure systems store consequences; narrative outcomes feed back into play.

2.10.4 The Lazy DV Table (GM Guidance)

Use this table for quick rulings. DV represents the *significance of the challenge*, not its intrinsic difficulty.

clp7.2cm	
DV Label When to Use It	
2 Easy	Competent effort; setbacks cause inconvenience or exposure.
3 Standard	Meaningful challenge with real stakes.
4 Hard	Time pressure, opposition, danger, or contested effort.
5 Extreme	High-risk actions where failure escalates the situation.
6 Legendary	Apex-tier challenges, climactic scenes, or mythic feats.

2.10.4.0.1 Default Rule: For a meaningful challenge, assume **DV = Tier + 2**. If the obstacle is beneath the characters' tier, do not roll.

Difficulty comes from **Position**, **Clocks**, and **Consequences**—not higher DVs.

2.10.5 Lazy Consequence Mapping

Consequences should scale with *pressure and tier*, not punish routine failure.

p3cmp9cm	
Pressure Default Consequence	
Low	Fictional complication, lost time, new exposure
Moderate	Fatigue (1) , Clock advance, Position downgrade
High	Fatigue (2) , Harm 1, major Clock advance
Severe	Harm 2+, capture, separation, or irreversible loss

2.10.5.0.1 Scaling Guidance:

- At higher Tiers, prefer **Fatigue**, **Clock pressure**, and **collateral fallout** over raw Harm.
- Harm represents failure to manage risk – not routine opposition.
- Equipment loss, asset damage, or narrative loss should follow clear fictional cause.

Harm is a consequence of escalation, not a default penalty.

2.10.6 Why Fatigue Comes Before Harm

2.10.6.0.1 Design Intent. Fatigue represents strain, stress, and narrowing options. Harm represents injury, trauma, or lasting damage.

Fatigue:

- Pressures future rolls
- Forces resource decisions (Boons, Talents, retreat)
- Encourages pacing and teamwork
- Keeps characters active in the scene

Harm:

- Removes options
- Shortens scenes
- Risks sidelining characters
- Escalates toward recovery or downtime

2.10.6.0.2 GM Guidance. Use Fatigue to say: “You can keep going, but it will cost you.” Use Harm to say: “You cannot ignore this.” If a consequence does not meaningfully change player decisions, it should not be Harm.

2.10.7 On Equipment Damage (Read This!)

2.10.7.0.1 Default Rule: Do **not** compromise equipment trivially.

Equipment damage should be:

- Rare
- Telegraphed
- Thematic
- Tied to meaningful stakes

2.10.7.0.2 Why. Trivial equipment loss:

- Feels punitive rather than dramatic
- Creates bookkeeping without tension
- Undermines player investment
- Disproportionately punishes martialists

2.10.7.0.3 Better Alternatives. Before damaging gear, consider:

- Temporary disadvantage (*jammed, misaligned, unstable*)
- Increased Fatigue to compensate for strain
- Clock advancement representing wear or attention
- Forced repositioning or exposure

2.10.7.0.4 When to Damage Equipment. Equipment damage is appropriate when:

- The fiction clearly targets the item
- A major Story Beat is spent
- The moment is climactic or symbolic
- The player knowingly risked it

Example: A shattered shield during a last stand is meaningful. A snapped sword on a routine miss is not.

2.10.8 DV Is Not Difficulty — It Is Commitment

A higher DV does *not* mean:

- harder math
- better challenge
- greater realism

A higher DV means:

- fewer partials
- fewer Boons
- faster escalation
- less room to recover

2.10.8.0.1 GM Heuristic. If you want:

- more tension → add Clocks
- more danger → spend Story Beats
- more drama → worsen Position
- more consequence → choose harsher costs

Raise DV only when the *fiction itself* demands commitment.

2.10.9 High-Tier Reminder

At Tier IV–V:

- dice pools are larger
- consequences carry greater narrative weight

Do **not** inflate DV to compensate.

High-tier difficulty emerges naturally from:

- Boon scarcity (fewer misses and partials mean fewer Boons)
- asset activation costs
- multi-threaded Clocks
- long-tail consequences

Let power feel earned, strained, and visible – never trivial.

2.10.9.0.1 GM Mantra.

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work.

First Session Cheat Sheet: The Pressure Engine in Action

[The Pressure Engine at a Glance]

This table distills the core mindset into actionable steps for your first session.

Critical Moment What to Do Why It Works	
Before the Session	Write the GM Mantra on a notecard: <i>“Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work.”</i> Place it where you’ll see it. Mindset matters first.
Introducing the Game	Say: <i>“Your failures will create opportunities. When you roll a 1, you gain power to shape the story.”</i> Reframes failure as narrative fuel.
Setting the Scene	Before any roll: 1. Listen: “What are you actually doing?” 2. Assign Position 3. State it aloud: “This is <i>[Position]</i>.” Makes Position the anchor.
When Players Roll	Note every 1 immediately. Ask: “What does this mean for the story?” 1s are the narrative engine.
On Partial Success	Don’t say “You succeed, but...” Say: “You succeed at a cost. What does this success cost?” Makes the scene dynamic.
When Setting DV	Start with DV 3 as your default. Only adjust if the fiction demands it. Prevents overcomplication.
When Stuck	Ask: “What’s at stake right now?” Not: “How hard should this be?” Aligns with core system logic.
After the Session	Write one sentence: <i>“What I learned: [your insight].”</i> Cements the mindset.
When in Doubt	Set Position to Controlled , DV to 3 , and ask: “What happens if this goes wrong?” The golden rule.

2.10.9.0.2 Final Note for GMs This table is not a rulebook. It is a compass. Use it until the rhythm of play becomes second nature.

Your First Combat: A GM Cheat Sheet

>p3cm p10cm

	Stage What to Do (Simplified)
Setup	Describe the immediate situation clearly: “You’re in a narrow hallway, back to the wall. Three bandits advance.” Skip initiative. Follow narrative flow – who acts first should be obvious. Start at Controlled Position unless the fiction strongly says otherwise.
Position	Dominant: Clear advantage (surprise, leverage, flanking). Controlled: Normal fighting (<i>most rolls</i>). Desperate: Cornered, outnumbered, or everything at stake. The GM always states Position before the roll. “This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, you’ll be disarmed.”
Dice Pool	Roll Attribute + Skill (e.g., Body + Melee). No extra math. Player states approach in fiction. Outcomes Clean Success: Goal achieved cleanly. Success with Cost: Goal achieved; spend 1 SB for complication. Partial: Progress at reduced scale, improved position, or hard choice. Miss: No progress; spend SB to escalate.
Story Beats	Spend SB aggressively but cleanly: 1 SB — Minor complication (“Steel sparks; you gain ground, but the noise carries.”) 2 SB — Moderate setback (“Your ally is knocked off-balance; their next roll is Desperate. ”) 3+ SB — Major shift (“Reinforcements arrive. New Clock: Escalation [4].”)
Clocks	Use one clock maximum in first combat (e.g., “Enemy Harm [4]”). Advance on Miss or Success-with-Cost. All clocks visible.
Multiple Enemies	Treat a group as one threat unless individuals act differently. One clock covers the group.
Boons	Players may spend 1 Boon to re-roll a die, improve Position, or activate an Asset. Gain 2 Boons on Miss, 1 on Partial.
What to Ignore	No miniatures or grids. No advanced maneuvers. No fatigue-position interactions. No multi-clock combat.
Next Session	Add <i>one</i> new element: a second clock, environmental pressure, or a structured combat arc. Introduce Three-Beat Combat later.

2.10.9.0.3 First Combat Rule of Thumb. Describe situation → State Position → Roll → Apply outcome → Spend SB once → Move forward. If the scene is moving, you’re doing it right.

The GM Mindset: Three Guiding Principles

>p0.25 X

Principle Guidance

1. Don't Fear Failure The dice are not your opposition—they are your collaborators. When unsure, ask: *“Does this create a more interesting story?”* If yes, lean into it. The system rewards bold GM decisions with momentum, not penalties.

2. Spend SB to Create Every Story Beat should open a new door, not close one. “The door slams shut” is weaker than “the door slams shut – but the echo draws guards closer.” Favor movement, pressure, and consequences over hard stops.

3. The Real DV Is in Stakes If a scene feels flat, raise the stakes – not the difficulty. Before the roll, be clear about what failure means. When players ask “What happens if I fail?”, answer honestly. That answer is where tension lives, not in higher numbers.

Encounter in Action: The Ambush at Raven's Ford

This example shows how the core systems—narrative initiative, Story Beats, Boons, Bonds, and damage—come together in play. The party consists of **Thane** (fighter), **Sariel** (rogue), and **Kestra** (mage).

Setup

The group crosses a rope bridge when two bandits attack from the far side. GM sets the scene:

“The bridge sways under your feet. Two crossbowmen take aim from behind a boulder. Thane, you’re closest to them. Sariel is mid-bridge, Kestra still on the near cliff.”

No initiative rolled. GM asks: “Who acts first?” Thane says, “I charge.” The GM agrees – he’s closest and has momentum.

Round 1 — Thane's Turn

Thane rushes the bandits. GM: “Exposed on the bridge, crossbows trained on you – Desperate, DV 3 to reach them before they shoot.” Thane rolls Body + Melee (6d10): 7,5,4,2,1,1 → two successes (7 only). One short → Miss.

2.10.9.0.4 Result: GM gains 2 SB (two 1s) and player gains 2 Boons. GM narrates:

“You make it halfway, but a bolt grazes your arm. Mark Harm 1. The bandits draw swords – they’re in Close now.”

Enemy Turn (No Roll)

Because Thane closed the distance, bandits “draw swords” as a consequence of his Miss. GM uses the 2 SB:

- **Spend 1 SB:** “The second bandit kicks a loose plank. The bridge lurches – everyone make Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be knocked Prone.”
- **Spend 1 SB:** “Sariel, your footing slips; your next action is Desperate.”

Sariel fails; she is Prone. Kestra succeeds.

Player Turn — Sariel Uses a Boon

Sariel stabs the nearest bandit from prone. GM: “Desperate, DV 3.” She rolls: no successes → Miss, gains 2 Boons (now has 2 total). Before GM narrates failure, she **spends 1 Boon** to re-roll one die. Re-roll comes up 6 → adds one success, turning Miss into Partial. GM: “You slash his leg – he drops to one knee, but your dagger is lodged. It’ll take a moment to free it.”

Bond Transfer

Kestra has a Bond with Sariel (“She saved me once; I owe her”). As a free action (Tier III+), Kestra **transfers 2 Boons** to Sariel. Sariel now has 3 Boons.

Kestra's Turn — Boon for Environmental Effect

Kestra uses magic to collapse part of the bridge behind the bandits. She has **Spellcraft** and [EARTH], [BREAK]. GM: “Controlled, DV 4. Spend a Boon to improve to Dominant?” Kestra spends 1 Boon (now Dominant, DV 4). She rolls successfully, generating 1 SB (a 1). GM spends that SB immediately:

“The bridge splinters – the bandits are isolated! But the shockwave also loosens the rope on your side. New Clock: Bridge Collapse [4].”

Damage not rolled. Bandits stranded – a fictional consequence.

End of Encounter

Sariel, with extra Boons, frees the dagger and finishes the wounded bandit (Clean Success). The other bandit surrenders. No enemy “damage” rolled: all consequences came from SB.

Chapter 3

Managing Resources

In **Fate's Edge**, resources are narrative levers, not inventory lists. From the last sip of water in sun-scorched wastes to the fragile loyalty of a Ykrul war-band, every resource tells a story, and every story demands its price. As GM, you are the keeper of these threads—the weaver of scarcity and abundance. This chapter shows how to manage the systems that fuel mortal ambitions and epic campaigns.

3.1 Supply Clock: The Pulse of Survival

The **Supply Clock** tracks the party's access to essentials: food, water, gear, and logistical support. It is a shared party resource—a narrative lever that tightens tension when characters are isolated, pursued, or cut off from civilization.

3.1.1 Supply Clock States

[Supply Clock Conditions] IX

Segments Filled	Narrative Effects
-----------------	-------------------

- | | |
|---------------|--|
| 0 (Full) | Well-equipped and prepared; no penalty. |
| 1 (Low) | Minor complications: bland rations, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins. |
| 2 (Dangerous) | Each character gains <i>Fatigue 1</i> as scarcity takes its toll. |
| 3 (Empty) | Severe penalties: starvation, dehydration, equipment failure imminent. |
-

3.1.2 When to Advance the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock advances when the world turns against the party's preparations:

- Extended travel through hostile lands without proper provisioning (see Travel Framework, §??).
- The GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on logistics failures or environmental hardships.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth.
- Failed **Survival** or **Craft** rolls related to hunting, foraging, or repair.

3.1.3 Clearing Supply Segments

The clock recedes when the party finds respite:

- Reaching civilization resets the clock to *Full*.
- A group **Survival** check (Wits + Survival, DV 2) in favorable conditions clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Successful provisioning (a good hunt, a discovered cache) can reduce segments.

3.1.3.0.1 Example. A week-long sea passage with uncertain winds. A failed **Navigation** roll causes the GM to spend 2 SB – filling two segments as supplies spoil. The party is now at *Low Supply*. A second failed roll fills another segment – *Dangerously Low*. Fatigue sets in. The sea gnaws at their endurance.

3.2 Fatigue: The Weight of the World

Fatigue represents the cumulative toll of journeying through a world that rarely offers comfort: exhaustion that seeps into bones, hunger that hollows cheeks, strain that clouds judgment. Each level of Fatigue forces the character to **re-roll one success** on their next action (cumulative).

3.2.1 Fatigue Effects

[Fatigue Progression] IX

Fatigue Level Effect

-
- 1 Re-roll one success (minor exhaustion, distracted)
 - 2 Re-roll two successes (noticeable weariness)
 - 3 Re-roll three successes (significant exhaustion, mental fog)
 - 4 Collapse, KO, or spiritual break (incapacitated)
-

3.2.2 Clearing Fatigue

Recovery requires genuine respite:

- A night's rest with adequate **Supply** removes 1 Fatigue.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is at *Dangerous* or *Empty Supply*.
- Medical attention (**Presence** + **Heal**, DV 2) during downtime can remove 1 Fatigue.

3.2.2.0.1 Narrative note: Fatigue is not only physical – it can reflect mental strain, grief, or spiritual exhaustion. A failed ritual might leave a caster at Fatigue 2 from metaphysical backlash alone.

3.2.3 Fatigue → Harm Conversion

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute. When the track fills:

1. Increase **Harm** by one level (0→Harm 1, Harm 1→Harm 2, Harm 2→Harm 3).
2. Clear all Fatigue.

This conversion can occur multiple times in a scene. (See Player's Guide for full Harm rules.)

3.3 Boons: The Currency of Resilience

Boons are narrative tokens earned by embracing risk. They reward *failure with opportunity* – the silver lining in clouds of defeat.

3.3.1 Earning Boons (GM Reminders)

- On a **Partial** (1 Boon) or **Miss** (2 Boons) with meaningful consequences (see Fail Forward in Player's Guide).
- Through clever or risky roleplay that drives the story.
- Via bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions.
- At GM discretion for exceptional collaborative play.

3.3.2 Boon Economy (Quick Reference)

- **Holding cap:** Maximum 5 Boons.
- **Carryover:** At end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess lost).
- **Conversion:** Once per session during downtime, convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP per session via conversion).

3.3.3 Spending Boons (Player Options)

Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the pool).
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities.

3.3.4 Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)

- **Once/Scene Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- **Repetition Rule:** Same approach + same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.
- **Position Gate:** *Dominant* tests with trivial fallout do not award Boons.

Design note: Boons reward narrative risk, not repeated failure.

3.4 Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self

Players can invest XP in **Followers** (on-screen allies) and **Assets** (off-screen resources). These are story agents with their own motivations and risks.

3.4.1 Followers: On-Screen Allies

Followers are bought with XP and tracked by a **Cap** (maximum assist bonus). Cost = Cap² XP; downtime 1–3 days to recruit.

3.4.1.0.1 Assisting in Scenes

- Assist dice equal $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{helper's relevant Skill})$.
- Total assist from all sources capped at +3 dice (except *Exceptional Coordination* talent allows +4 from one follower).
- Only one follower may assist a given action.

3.4.1.0.2 Follower Independent Actions Once per scene (party-wide), a follower may take a small independent action:

- **Scout & Signal** – Change an ally's next action to *Dominant*.

- **Distract & Draw** – Reduce a threat/hunt/escape clock by 1 tick.
- **Fetch & Carry** – Move a small object through danger.

Cost: Mark Exposure +1 or Harm 1 on that follower.

3.4.1.0.3 Follower Upkeep and Risk

- Each downtime, pay XP equal to Cap **or** spend a scene tending the relationship.
- Neglect → follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).
- If the GM spends **2+ SB** on an action you take with assistance, they may mark Exposure or Harm on the follower instead of other consequences (fiction first).
- **Off-Screen Capability:** Once per downtime, a Cap 3+ follower can solve a significant problem but generates **1 SB** for the party (the GM describes the resulting complication).

3.4.1.0.4 Follower Condition Followers track two meters:

Exposure – Attention, stress, narrative pressure.

Harm – Injury, trauma, damage.

State: *Maintained* (full) → *Neglected* (–1 die) → *Compromised* (unavailable).

3.4.2 Assets: Off-Screen Influence

Assets are titles, safehouses, spy rings, charters. They do not act in scenes directly but change the fiction between sessions.

[Asset Tiers] IX

Tier Cost and Examples

Minor 4 XP (1 day) – safehouse, small shop, local contact.

Standard 8 XP (1 week) – noble title, spy ring, workshop.

Major 12 XP (1 month) – city license, fortress lease, regional network.

3.4.2.0.1 Using Assets

- **Off-Screen Effect:** Use once per session for free (the quiet work between adventures).
- **On-Screen Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to use the asset dramatically in a scene.
- **Downtime Activation:** Pay 2 XP or 1 Boon to activate an asset at campaign start or during downtime.
- Asset must have plausible scope for the intended effect.

3.4.2.0.2 Asset Upkeep Each downtime:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Cost = $\max(1, \text{AcquisitionXP}/3)$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- Failure to pay → asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

3.4.2.0.3 Asset Condition

Maintained – Full capability.

Neglected – –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised – Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

3.5 XP Awards: Growth Through Choice

XP is earned through genuine engagement, not attendance. Use these guidelines at the end of each session.

[XP Award Guidelines] IX

Award Range

Table Attendance +2 XP

Major Objective +2–4 XP

Discovery / Lore +1–2 XP

Hard Choice +1–2 XP

Complication Spotlight +1–3 XP

Bond / Flag Driven Play +1–2 XP

GM Curveball +0–3 XP

3.5.1 Milestones

At the end of a major story arc:

- +8–12 XP to all players.
- +2 XP bonus to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

3.6 Campaign Resources: Mandate and Crisis

Two campaign-level clocks track the party's influence and the world's resistance.

3.6.1 Mandate Clock (0–6)

Tracks the party's public legitimacy.

- **High Mandate:** Allies seek them out, resources flow, doors open.
- **Low Mandate:** Suspicion, bureaucratic obstacles, support withers.

Advance the clock when the party gains renown (clean victories, public accolades) or loses face (scandals, broken oaths).

3.6.2 Crisis Clock (0–6)

Tracks the opposition's growing strength.

- **Rising Crisis:** Complications escalate, enemies grow bolder.
- **Managed Crisis:** Breathing room, opportunities to strike back.

Advance the clock when the party fails key objectives, ignores looming threats, or the GM spends SB on faction escalation.

3.7 Combat Resource Management

In combat, resource management takes on desperate urgency.

3.7.1 Supply in Combat

- **Intense Combat:** GM may spend 1 SB to fill 1 Supply segment (arrows break, waterskins puncture).
- **Prolonged Engagement:** Each hour of sustained combat adds 1 Supply segment.
- **Ammunition Depletion:** Ranged weapons may run low, requiring scavenging actions (e.g., **Craft** roll to recover arrows).

3.7.2 Fatigue in Combat

- Characters with existing Fatigue re-roll additional successes equal to their Fatigue level each round (cumulative).
- Reaching 4 Fatigue during combat causes immediate collapse (incapacitated).
- Fatigue cannot be cleared during active combat.

3.7.3 Follower Combat Integration

- Followers assist using their Cap (see 3.4.1).
- 2+ SB spent in combat can endanger an assisting follower (mark Exposure or Harm).
- Followers can take combat-relevant independent actions (cost: Exposure +1 or Harm 1).
- After a follower acts twice in a high-risk combat scene, mark Exposure +1.

3.7.4 Tactical Clocks

Tactical clocks represent persistent combat conditions that drain party resources.

[Tactical Clock Effects] IX

Clock Resource Drain

Mob Overwhelm [6] Accelerates Supply depletion and Fatigue.

Fatigue Spiral [4] Accelerates existing Fatigue, makes each action harder.

Morale Collapse [6] Generates SB, reduces effectiveness.

Environmental Collapse [8] Creates new Supply and safety concerns.

3.7.5 Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 structural advantages, the GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- Choose: start one obstacle at +1 DV, **or** bank +1 SB for the first Deck Twist.
- Over-Stack applies only to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play.

3.8 Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger

In Fate's Edge, arrows, rations, and waterskins are tracked only in the fiction that surrounds them. Mechanics engage only when those resources become scarce enough to matter. The focus remains always on **narrative tension** – the gnawing hunger, the fading light, the last arrow – not sterile bookkeeping.

GM Reminder: When a player asks “Do I have enough arrows?” the answer is almost always “yes” until it becomes dramatically interesting to say “no.” Similarly, track Supply only when the party is isolated, pursued, or in a hostile environment. Let the world breathe with its own needs and abundances. And when the dice say the world pushes back against mortal plans – **listen to what they tell you about the price of ambition.**

Chapter 4

Magic and Backlash

In **Fate's Edge**, magic is not a clean or safe art practiced in sterile towers. It is a **dangerous negotiation with forces beyond mortal comprehension**. As the GM, your role is to make magic **feel weighty, thematic, and alive with risk**. This chapter provides tools for adjudicating magical actions, managing consequences, and keeping the story at the forefront.

*For player-facing rules (spellcasting, Rites, Invoker symbols, Cantor songs, etc.), see the **Player's Guide**. This chapter focuses on your role as GM.*

4.1 The Role of Magic in Your Game

Magic in Fate's Edge is:

- **Consequential** – Every spell can change the fiction, for good or ill.
- **Risky** – Even success may generate Story Beats (SB) that you spend to complicate the moment.
- **Thematic** – Backlash should reflect the elements and Patrons involved.
- **Creative** – Reward inventive uses, but keep scope within the players' tier.

Your primary job is not to block magic, but to **frame costs, apply consequences, and escalate drama**. When a player wants to cast a spell, ask:

- What do they want to achieve?
- Which elements or Patrons are involved?
- What is at stake if it goes wrong?

4.2 Adjudicating Magic at the Table

Setting Difficulty Value (DV) and Position

Use the standard DV ladder (2–5+), but consider magical specifics:

[DV for Magic] IX

DV When to Use

2 Routine cantrip, minor sensory effect, no opposition.

- 3 Standard combat spell, small environmental change, contested but fair.
- 4 Complex working, area effect, strong opposition, dangerous ritual.
- 5+ Legendary magic, rewriting reality, binding a major Outsider.

4.2.0.0.1 Position for Magic

- **Dominant:** Caster has ritual preparation, rare components, or surprise.
- **Controlled:** Standard casting under normal conditions.
- **Desperate:** Caster is wounded, rushed, or in an anti-magic zone.

Position affects the severity of backlash (see below).

Range Bands for Magic

Spells and effects have natural range limits based on their tags and fiction. Use these guidelines:

Range Band	Typical Spells
Close	Touch, personal aura, short cone.
Near	Same room/zone, thrown magics, most combat spells.
Far	Across a battlefield, line of sight without obstacles.
Absent	Ritual scrying, long-distance teleportation (requires setup).

4.2.0.0.2 Adjusting Range: A spell can be extended one band by increasing DV by 1, adding a SB, or requiring an extra action. Extreme range (e.g., scrying a distant city) should be a ritual, not a single roll.

When to Say Yes, No, or Yes, But

- **Yes:** Effect is clearly within the caster's tier, tags, and fictional logic.
- **No:** The effect would break the campaign premise, destroy a mystery, or invalidate another player's niche. Offer alternatives.
- **Yes, But:** The effect works, but at a cost: increased DV, higher SB generation, a clock, or an immediate narrative complication.

Handling Creative Player Ideas

When a player tries something unexpected:

1. Listen to the description. What do they want to achieve?
2. Ask for the tags or elements involved. If none, help them add one.
3. Set DV and Position based on scope and risk.
4. Clearly state the stakes: "If you fail, the spell will backfire and also alert the guards."
5. Let the dice decide, then spend SB to make the outcome interesting.

4.3 Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a magical action, you gain Story Beats (SB). Spend them to create backlash – complications that fit the magic's element and the fiction.

SB Spend Menu for Magic

[Spend SB on Magical Complications] IX

SB Cost Example Backlash

-
- 1 SB Minor flare, eerie sound, brief sensory distortion, gear lightly scorched.
 2 SB Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), spell draws attention, caster loses balance (Position -1).
 3 SB Patron omen, secondary target affected, magical feedback (Harm 1 to caster).
 4+ SB Reality warps – zone gains a temporary tag, Patron manifests a demand, a new threat appears.
-

Elemental Backlash Examples

Use these to color your complications:

Element	Sample Backlash
Fire	Smoke, heat exhaustion, small secondary fire, blinding flare.
Water	Flooding, slippery footing, emotional surge, dampness ruining supplies.
Earth	Tremor, dust cloud, immobilising stone grip, cracked floor.
Air	Sudden gust, deafening thunder, scatters important items, voice lost.
Fate	Prophetic nightmare, doors close, a crucial option disappears.
Luck	Allied misfortune, fragile success, random complication.
Life	Overgrowth, healing surge on enemy, parasitic plants.
Death	Ghostly whisper, chill, memory loss, premature decay.

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

4.4 Managing Obligation and Corruption

Players track their own Obligation and Corruption, but you enforce thresholds and create consequences.

Obligation Overflow and Patron Intrusions

When a character exceeds their Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence):

- For each segment over capacity, mark 1 Fatigue (player does this).
- If they exceed ****double capacity****, clear all Fatigue, mark Harm 1, and trigger a **Patron Intrusion** – a narrative demand or complication from the Patron.

4.4.0.0.1 Examples of Patron Intrusions

- The Patron appears in a dream: “Do this task for me, or else.”
- A rival servant of the same Patron arrives to collect a debt.
- The Patron’s mark becomes visible on the character’s skin, causing social trouble.
- A faction aligned with the Patron forcibly recruits the character.

Corruption as a Narrative Track

Corruption (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers) fills from pushes, resonant rites, and your SB spends. When the clock fills:

- Apply the Patron’s “benefit and burden” (see Patron tables in Player’s Guide).
- Reset the clock to the character’s Tier minimum.
- If the player embraces corruption, give them a permanent thematic quirk (not a pure penalty).

4.5 Summoning (GM-Facing)

For full summoning mechanics, see the Player’s Guide (Pact-Whisperer). Here are your key responsibilities:

What to Watch For

- **Leash ticking:** Tick the Leash whenever the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, the summoner splits focus, or the spirit crosses a [WARD] (test DV = Cap).
- **Boon Finesse:** Players may spend 1 Boon once per round to clear 1 tick (before the Leash fills).
- **Quick Commands:** Simple orders (attack nearest, hold, fetch) do not cost the summoner’s action. Complex commands do.

When the Spirit Acts on Its Own

On a Miss, or when the Leash fills, the spirit acts once according to its nature before departing (or turning hostile). Use this to introduce a complication:

- A fire elemental sets the nearest structure ablaze.
- A shadow spirit whispers a secret to an enemy.
- A guardian spirit defends the wrong person.

Spirit Specializations (Quick Reference)

If a player develops a bonded spirit, you may grant one specialization from this list:

- **Combat:** +1 Harm melee, ignore first Harm on attacks.
- **Scout:** Stealthy; Cap 1 carries 2kg, Cap 3 carries 10kg.
- **Utility:** Simple tasks (carrying, opening doors).
- **Shield:** Interpose; convert Harm to Fatigue.

4.6 Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)

Cantors use Songs (Low Rites) with a Corruption Clock. Your main tasks:

- Track the Corruption Clock only when the player marks it (they manage it).
- On a fill, impose the last Patron’s benefit burden (from Patron tables).
- Spend SB to represent social fallout, Patron omens, or magical residue from their performances.

Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, a Cantor can shift all allies’ Position +1 for one exchange. If they use it again in the same scene, they mark toward Corruption accumulation. This is a non-stacking aura; only the best shift applies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If a Cantor performs a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, they may found a Chorus. This grants a minor follower benefit, but they must mark Obligation each session they use it. If neglected, the cult fractures – you can introduce a rival sect or a scandal.

4.7 Ritual Magic (GM Advice)

Rituals are powerful but slow. Use them for effects that are too big for a single roll.

Setting DV for Rituals

- **Low Ritual (DV 3–4):** 10–15 minutes, affects a room or small area.
- **Standard Ritual (DV 4–5):** 30 minutes, affects a building or a scene.
- **High Ritual (DV 5+):** Hours, affects a district or narrative turning point.

Using Helpers

Helpers can reduce DV by 1 each (max –2) or absorb 1 SB of backlash. They must have relevant skills (Arcana, Lore, etc.). Interrupting a helper may disrupt the ritual.

Pacing and Interruption

If a ritual is interrupted, treat as a Miss on the casting roll. You may also:

- Advance a doomsday clock.
- Summon an unexpected entity.
- Damage a needed component.

4.8 Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar

Adjudicating Psionics

Psionics is power without intermediaries – no Patrons, no symbols. As GM, ensure it feels precise yet costly.

Core Principles:

- Set DV by precision, not raw power. Clear intent = lower DV.
- Generate SB frequently – mental strain, sensory bleed, NPC suspicion.
- Respect consent: unwilling minds always resist.
- On Partial, offer hard choices: surface thoughts only, emotional truth without context.
- Distinguish from spellcraft: psionics excels at direct influence, not environmental change.

Example Backlash: headache, nosebleed, fleeting vision, target becomes aware of intrusion, caster loses focus (Fatigue 1).

4.9 Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)

Spend SB for Magical Complications

SB	Effect
1	Minor flare, noise, caster off-balance (–1 die next action).
2	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), draws attention, Position –1.
3	Patron omen, magical feedback (Harm 1), new clock (e.g., “Leaking Energy”).
4+	Reality warp, Patron manifestation, scene shifts (fire, flood, etc.).

Elemental Backlash Quick Picks

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Major (3+ SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks	Uncontrolled fire, explosion
Water	Slick floor, damp	Flooding, emotional storm
Earth	Dust, tremor	Collapse, binding
Air	Gust, ringing ears	Hurricane, deafness
Fate	Option closes	Prophecy becomes fixed
Luck	Small misfortune	A friend suffers the failure
Life	Overgrowth	Parasite, fever
Death	Chill whispers	A ghost manifests

Patron Intrusion Examples

Patron Type	Sample Intrusion
Everflame (Oath)	“Prove your purity – destroy that heretical text.”
The Traveler	“You must guide a lost soul to their destination.”
Inquisitor Prime	“Report any unsanctioned magic you witness.”
Malachai	“Curse someone weaker than you before dawn.”

Final GM Reminder

Magic is a narrative engine. Use Story Beats to create drama, not to punish. When in doubt, let the spell work and complicate the result. The world should react – but always in a way that keeps the story moving.

“Set the DV low. Spend SB to make the cost visible. Let the fiction lead.”